

THE MONEY HEALING SERIES

Investing for People Who Don't Trust the Market

*A Skeptic's Guide to Building Wealth
Anyway*

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Why Skepticism About Investing Is Rational

The financial industry has given people plenty of reasons not to trust it. Your skepticism is not uninformed.

What the Industry Gets Wrong

Actively managed funds, on average, underperform their benchmark index after fees. The financial industry knows this. The mutual fund industry exists anyway because fees are very profitable.

Market crashes are real. 2000, 2008, 2020 — portfolios lose 30–50% in a bad cycle. For people who lived through these, the idea that 'just stay invested' is easy advice is understandably infuriating.

Your skepticism about flashy stock picks, day trading, crypto speculation, and miracle returns is well-founded. But those are not the same as broad, boring, low-cost index investing.

*"Skepticism about bad investing is wisdom.
Skepticism about all investing is expensive."*

The Only Strategy That Has Consistently Worked

Boring has outperformed exciting for 100 years.

The Index Fund Case

If you had invested \$10,000 in an S&P; 500 index fund in 1994 and never touched it, you would have approximately \$240,000 by 2024 — through multiple crashes, recessions, wars, pandemics, and political crises.

The strategy: buy a low-cost total market or S&P; 500 index fund. Add money consistently. Never sell based on market conditions. Wait 20–30 years.

This is not exciting. It does not require skill. It does not require following the market. The research supporting it is extensive and bipartisan. It is the most well-documented wealth-building strategy in history for ordinary investors.

"Boring investments build real wealth. Exciting ones mostly build financial media revenue."

Getting Started With Real Money

The gap between understanding investing and doing it is almost entirely emotional.

Opening an Account in 20 Minutes

Fidelity, Vanguard, and Charles Schwab all offer commission-free accounts you can open online in under 20 minutes. You do not need a minimum balance to open a Fidelity or Schwab account.

Once open: transfer a small amount — \$100, \$500, whatever you can actually afford. Buy one index fund. VOO (Vanguard S&P; 500 ETF), FSKAX (Fidelity Total Market), or SCHB (Schwab US Broad Market) are good starting points with expense ratios under 0.05%.

You don't need to understand everything. You need to own something. The learning comes from having skin in the game.

"You learn investing by doing it with real money, not by preparing indefinitely."

Managing Fear During Downturns

The only way to lose money in an index fund long-term is to sell when it's down.

Why Staying Invested Is Hard

The psychological experience of watching your portfolio drop 30% is genuinely painful. Research shows that financial losses activate the same pain centers as physical harm, and that losses feel approximately twice as bad as equivalent gains feel good.

This asymmetry is why people sell low. Not because they're foolish — because the emotional experience of loss is overwhelming.

The preparation for downturns happens before they occur: understand that they are normal (the market has declined 20%+ twelve times since 1950 and recovered every time), have an emergency fund so you don't need to sell during bad markets, and automate contributions so the habit continues regardless of your emotional state.

"The investor who stays invested wins. Not the one who times the market."

What to Do With \$1,000, \$10,000, \$100,000

The right move at different balances is slightly different — but simpler than most people think.

Each Threshold

\$1,000: Open a Roth IRA. Buy one index fund. Set a \$50/month automatic contribution. Do not touch it.

\$10,000: Max your Roth IRA contribution for the year (\$7,000 in 2024 if under 50). Put the remainder in a taxable brokerage account in the same index fund.

\$100,000: Max 401(k) if available (up to \$23,000 in 2024). Max Roth IRA. Remaining in taxable brokerage in a three-fund portfolio (total US market, international index, bond index). Consider speaking with a fee-only fiduciary financial advisor.

At every level: low cost, diversified, automated, long-term.

"Simplicity compounds just as reliably as complexity — with less risk."

The Long Game With Eyes Open

Investing for the long term doesn't require optimism. It requires patience and a basic understanding of history.

What You're Actually Betting On

Broad market investing is not a bet that any particular company will succeed. It's a bet that human productivity and economic activity will continue — that the collective output of millions of businesses will be larger in 30 years than today.

This has been true through every war, recession, pandemic, and political crisis in recorded economic history. It may not always be true. But the alternatives — keeping everything in cash, which inflation erodes reliably — carry their own risks.

You're not betting on a perfect future. You're betting on a functional one.

"Investing isn't optimism. It's a reasonable bet on human resilience."
